CONTENDERS

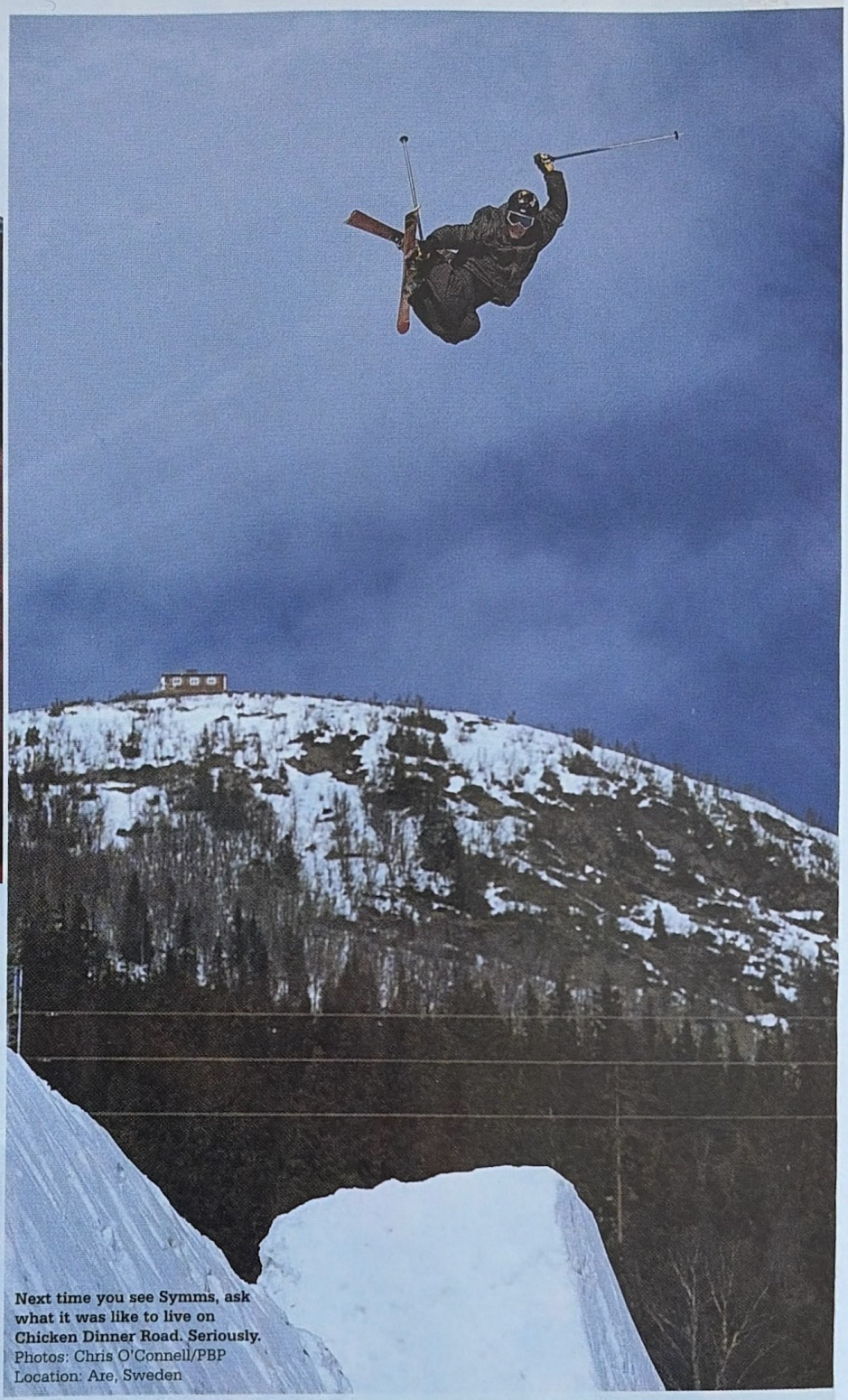
JOHN SYMMS

Age: 19
Residing: Salt Lake City, Utah
Sponsors: Salomon, Scott USA, Orage, Park City Mountain Resort

What was it like growing up in Idaho?
The skiing wasn't great, but otherwise Idaho is pretty nice. I grew up on a farm.

So you came onto the freeskiing scene out of nowhere, literally.
Yeah ... back in Idaho I didn't have the resources that are available to me now. Nobody really knew who I was. When I moved to Salt Lake City last winter to go to the University of Utah, people started seeing me.

Are you primarily a competition skier?
I enjoy competing because the pressure helps me ski better. It doesn't make me nervous anymore. So yeah, I would call myself a competition skier. But at the same time I wouldn't really mind if I didn't have to compete. That would be nice. I guess if I had one or two big seasons, maybe I wouldn't.



Next time you see Symms, ask what it was like to live on Chicken Dinner Road. Seriously.
Photos: Chris O'Connell/PBP
Location: Are, Sweden

What was the first thing you did after you qualified for the X Games?
I actually had to get in a car and drive back to Salt Lake City right away so I could explain to my professors why I would be missing more classes.

Miss any tests?
No, but I did have a big math test the day after the U.S. Freeskiing Open. I got back to school at 4:00 a.m. Monday morning and woke up like three hours later to take it.

Did you fail miserably?
I got around an 80 percent or something. Pretty shitty.

Maybe for you. But then again, you're on a full academic scholarship.
Yeah.

And that's why you went to college in Utah?
Well, they offered me the most money, but I went there for the skiing. They have the best in the world, as far as I'm concerned.—**Jeff Foss**